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De Blauwe Scheen earns a special place amongst over 50 projects carried out by changing groups of printers since 1981. Jan Keijser and Hans van Eijk are the people behind the name which has diverse sources of inspiration: 'De Blauwe Schuit', the legendary collective formed around the printer H.N. Werkman; the poem 'De Lof van een Blauwe Scheen' [In Praise of a Blue Shin] by Roemer Visscher; and, last but not least, by the fact that 'scheen' is another word for 'kooi' [quoin], a printer's tool used to wedge the lines of composed lead type firmly within the frame.

Of the five projects organized to date by the pair, De grote Nederlandse letterproef [The great Dutch type specimen] (1998) is the most impressive for various reasons. First and foremost, there is the consistency of the content. With most projects, a theme is specified and each printer decides how this will be fulfilled. In the case of the Letterproef, each printer received a short prose piece by Jacob Israël de Haan, who had articles published in various periodicals from 1905 to 1909. The enthusiasm for participation was so overwhelming that the corpus had to be expanded with a selection from a series of travel stories for children, which De Haan wrote for a Sunday paper in 1903 and 1904. Sixty printers received texts, the greatest number ever achieved by any such project.

What really makes the project so special is that, as the name suggests, it also constitutes a type specimen. Each printer was assigned a type and, besides the prose fragment, was asked to submit a complete type family (i.e., all available typefaces: lower case, capitals, small capitals, numbers, diacriticals, ligatures, etc.) and discuss its origins and the designer.

The result is astonishing because there is no better range of type specimens available to printers at the end of the lead era. Of course no commercial printing firm existed that possessed such a great variety, but because the marginal printers had already combed the entire Netherlands in their hunt for type, there was still much more preserved than the classic eternal Garamond, Bodoni, Hollandsche Mediaeval and Nobel. The combination of text and type specimen lends the publication a special charm. Type specimens usually comprise just a few lines of text to give an idea of the type, but here, by using a longer fragment, every type has the chance to make a full impression.

With every project there are participants who make their contribution with an minimum effort and those who give it their all. Fortunately it is the dedicated who dominate the Letterproef and almost every contribution exudes the pleasure spent in its design and printing. For how long did Arjaan van Nimwegen of the Bucheliuspers sweat over a silhouette portrait of Paul Verlaine, built up of simple square blocks? And what about Gert van Oortmerssen of De Dwarsbomen who made his own paper for his contribution?

Most telling of the effort required is the exceptionally colourful illustrated contribution of De vergulde maatlat/Treemapers of Karel Treebus, who took on Libra. The colophon states, 'In the autumn of 1997, 35 print runs were made' for this contribution, the first on the day of the Queen's speech to Parliament in September and the last on St. Nicholas Eve, 5 December: 'Due to a limited type collection, the text had to be composed and printed per line'.

Another contribution for which the hours were not counted is that of Gerard Post van der Molen. Those who know his solo project, Het groeiboek would not be surprised that he used Hollandsche Mediaeval, and how! The letter can be admired in nine body sizes and roman and italic have been used as much as possible. In addition his contribution also contains much worthwhile information about the type and some 'replicas' composed with great care, including one of the original announcements of Hollandsche Mediaeval from 1912. An 'urgent appeal' to the reader to help De Ammoniet to complete its collection of this very large and diverse type family is a fitting conclusion to the whole.

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